

VA.3 Inspection Sequence

The inspections Virginia's building code requires, in order — what each one checks, what happens when one fails, and a log to record every result as you go.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. Virginia has one statewide building code, but every county, city, and town enforces it through its own local building department, with its own forms, fees, and portal. Confirm every item with the building department that will issue your permit before you rely on it. The USBC sets the minimum inspection list; your building department schedules them and may inspect more — its instructions govern.

WHAT THE STATE SETS AND WHAT YOUR LOCALITY SETS

The list below is statewide: USBC § 113.3 names the minimum inspections every Virginia building department must perform on your house, and this document quotes each one verbatim. How they are scheduled, whether trades are called together or separately, and anything your department adds on top is local practice. The governing principle sits in § 113.1: *"any building or structure may be inspected at any time before completion and shall not be deemed in compliance until approved."* Nothing counts until it is inspected and approved — so never cover work that has not been.

USBC § 113.1, § 113.3 (13VAC5-63-130). Verified August 2026.

No owner-present rule — but be there anyway

Some states forbid inspecting an owner-builder's job without the owner on site. Virginia's statutes and the USBC sections this kit verified impose no such requirement — so this document does not invent one. Attend every inspection you can regardless: the ten-minute conversation with the inspector at footing is the cheapest education you will get all build.

THE SEQUENCE — THE SEVEN REQUIRED INSPECTIONS, VERBATIM

The statewide minimum inspection list — USBC § 113.3

Inspection	The code's words, and what they mean on site	Code
1. Footing	<i>"Inspection of footing excavations and reinforcement material for concrete footings prior to the placement of concrete."</i> Trenches open, rebar placed and supported — and no concrete until the approval is in hand.	§ 113.3(1)

The statewide minimum inspection list — USBC § 113.3

Inspection	The code's words, and what they mean on site	Code
2. Foundation	<i>"Inspection of foundation systems during phases of construction necessary to ensure compliance with this code."</i> Walls, waterproofing, anchorage — your department decides which phases it looks at; ask when you pull the permit.	§ 113.3(2)
3. Pre-concrete	<i>"Inspection of preparatory work prior to the placement of concrete."</i> Slabs and flatwork: everything the pour will bury — under-slab plumbing and electrical, vapor barrier, fill — complete first.	§ 113.3(3)
4. Framing	<i>"Inspection of structural members and fasteners prior to concealment."</i> The framing inspection: structure complete, connections visible, nothing covered.	§ 113.3(4)
5. Trade rough-ins	<i>"Inspection of electrical, mechanical and plumbing materials, equipment, and systems prior to concealment."</i> Everything that will hide inside walls, floors and ceilings — before insulation, before drywall. Localities differ on whether trades are called together or separately.	§ 113.3(5)
6. Energy	<i>"Inspection of energy conservation material prior to concealment."</i> Virginia gives energy its own concealment inspection — insulation, air barrier and sealing details, checked before any wall or ceiling covering goes on.	§ 113.3(6)
7. Final	<i>"Final inspection."</i> The whole house, complete. This is where the paper lands too: the blower-door result and the signed duct-test report go to the code official (see VA.2, section E).	§ 113.3(7)

All seven quoted from USBC § 113.3 (13VAC5-63-130), verified August 2026. The list is the statewide minimum — your department may inspect "at any time before completion" under § 113.1 and may look at more than the minimum.

WHEN AN INSPECTION FAILS — AND WHO ELSE CAN INSPECT

Defects must be fixed before they disappear. Under USBC § 113.6, defective work must be corrected and reinspected *"before any work proceeds that would conceal such defects"* — and the official gives you written approval, or a written notice of defects. Keep every one of those papers with this log. Whether your locality charges for a failed reinspection is a local fee-schedule question: fees are levied locally — *"fees may be levied by the local governing body in order to defray the cost of such enforcement and appeals"* (§ 36-105(B)) — and there is no statewide reinspection fee rule, so **get the fee schedule when your permit issues.**

Third-party inspections exist, on the official's terms. *"The building official may accept reports of inspections and tests from individuals or inspection agencies approved in accordance with the building official's written policy required by Section 113.7.1."* (§ 113.7) If your department is slow to schedule, ask whether it has such a policy and which agencies it has approved. This kit prints no deadline that forces the option open — the timing trigger sometimes quoted for § 113.7 was not verified, so do not rely on one.

USBC § 113.6, § 113.7 (13VAC5-63-130); § 36-105(B). Verified August 2026.

THE CERTIFICATE AT THE END — USBC § 116

"Prior to occupancy or change of occupancy of a building or structure, a certificate of occupancy shall be obtained in accordance with this section." (§ 116.1) You do not move in — not a mattress, not a toothbrush — before it issues. If part of the house is genuinely done and safe, there is a statutory bridge: "Upon the request of a permit holder, a temporary certificate of occupancy may be issued before the completion of the work covered by a permit," where the portion occupied is safe (§ 116.1.1).

On timing: Section 116 directs the building official to issue the certificate within five working days after the approved final inspection once compliance is verified — **that sentence is a paraphrase of the section, not quoted text**; confirm the timing with your building department rather than planning your move around it. And remember the string from VA.1: an owner who built under the § 54.1-1101(A)(7) exemption must obtain the CO **before conveying the property to a buyer**, absent the buyer's written waiver (§ 54.1-1101(B)).

USBC § 116.1, § 116.1.1 (13VAC5-63-160); § 54.1-1101(B). Verified August 2026.

INSPECTION LOG — RECORD EVERY ONE

Fill this in as it happens, not from memory. If a result is ever disputed, or a later inspector questions earlier work, this page and your photos are the record you have. Rows are provided for the trades called separately and for the two energy tests — cross out what your department does not use.

Inspection log

Inspection	Called	Held	Result	Inspector	Corrections required / notes
Footing					
Foundation					
Pre-concrete / slab					
Framing					
Electrical rough-in					
Plumbing rough-in					
Mechanical rough-in					
Energy / insulation					
Blower-door test					

Inspection log

Inspection	Called	Held	Result	Inspector	Corrections required / notes
Duct leakage test					
Final — building					

Certificate of occupancy issued: _____ Number: _____

Sources (verified August 2026; USBC sections at law.lis.virginia.gov/admincode, title 13, agency 5, chapter 63). Nothing deemed in compliance until approved — § 113.1. The seven minimum inspections, quoted verbatim — § 113.3. Defects corrected and reinspected before concealment; written approval or notice — § 113.6. Third-party reports under the official's written policy — § 113.7. Fees, including any reinspection fee, are local — § 36-105(B). Certificate of occupancy before occupancy, and the temporary CO — § 116.1, § 116.1.1; the five-working-day issuance timing is a paraphrase of § 116 — confirm it locally. CO before conveying to a buyer — § 54.1-1101(B). Blower-door and duct-test reports — 13VAC5-63-264, covered in VA.2.